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Introduction to Biblical Studies

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Peter and the Rock

There has been much debate over the centuries as to what Jesus intended when he said, “you are Peter (Petros), and upon this rock (petra) I will build My church” (Matt 16:18, NASB95). As Luz points out, there are three ways often used to interpret “rock.” Jesus may be using “rock” in reference to Peter’s confession, to Jesus himself as the foundation, or that Peter is the pope (including those who succeed him).

There are many factors that go into these different interpretations. Some factors justified, such as a desire to consider the whole New Testament’s view of the foundation of the church as seen in the “Christ is the fundamental rock of the church” (Luz, pg. 373) interpretation. However, some are less noble like those who take either position that claims that Peter is not the foundation in order to combat Catholicism (it must be noted that not all who take either of these positions are doing so to combat Catholicism). Each reader must approach the argument as Luz’s does, open to all sides. The text was not written to combat, or promote, certain sides of later centuries’ arguments. The text was written to mean something for the audience in the evangelist’s day. Attempting to understand that meaning ought to be the goal.

France takes a very helpful, straightforward approach to the debate. He notes that since the name *Petros* is “virtually unknown as a personal name in the ancient world,” then “it [is] the

more probable that Jesus chose it for Simon with a view to its literal meaning. He is to be a ‘Rock’” (France, pg. 620-1). He goes on to argue that there is no use of the word “Petros” in the LXX or other pieces of relevant literature, including the New Testament, so “the Greek reader would therefore see here a difference in form but not in meaning, since *petros* was not now (if it ever had been) the term for a ‘stone’” (France, pg. 621). In addition to this, if the assumption that Jesus was speaking Aramaic is correct, he most likely would have used the Aramaic word “kēphā” for both Simon’s new name and “this rock.” One might ask, “why did the text use *Petros* and *petra* instead of just one term?” France answers it by saying that the reason *Petros* is used is because Simon, being a man, needed a masculine name (France, pg. 621).

France goes on to note the common argument that “this rock” is not Peter, but his faith. France disagrees, stating that “the wordplay points decisively toward Peter” (France, pg. 622). He argues that Peter *is* the rock, but not in the same way that Jesus is the cornerstone. Instead, what Jesus has in view is Peter’s role in the events recorded in the book of Acts. It is Peter who preaches the first sermon, converts Samaritans, and is the first to understand that God accepts even Gentiles with the conversion of Cornelius. Jesus, in Matt 16:18, foreshadows Peter’s vital role in the building of God’s church. Thus, “All... apologetic rewritings of the passage are in any case beside the point, since there is nothing in this passage about any successors to Peter” (France, pg. 622).

Allison takes a different, yet similar approach to this topic. Allison agrees with France against Luz (who seems to hold the position that Christ is the rock). Allison believes that Peter is the rock. However, he considers the “mythological background” (Allison, pg. 627) of what Jesus may have been imagining when he used the term “the rock.” He notes the possible connection to 2 Sam 7 with the temple including “the concept of the people of God as a temple” which “was

well known in both Judaism and early Christianity” (Allison, pg. 627). Allison notes that since the rock under the temple is at the center of the world, linking heaven and hades with Jesus’s reference to “the gates of Hades,” the reader may see an image of “the church [being] at the centre of the cosmos, sitting on top of the powers of evil” (Allison, pg. 628). The author, then, views the usage of temple-related imagery to point to “the rock” being not just Peter in view, but also an allusion to the people of God, which are often biblically seen as being a building.

When consulting these three resources, I found that the most helpful source for understanding the topic was France. As a whole, he was easy-to-follow and provided a good entrance to the discussion while also providing good commentary. However, the most helpful in understanding the different arguments from this text was Luz. I did not find Allison’s very helpful. I read his material after France, so it did not add much to my understanding besides the concept of the rock having a possible 2 Sam 7 connection (temple and God’s people).

While some who hold either the position that Christ is the foundation or that the rock is Peter’s faith find them more probable, I would disagree. I find the argument that Peter is the rock to be the most compelling and straightforward solution. I am not in favor of discrediting the “Peter is the rock” argument simply because of Catholicism’s usage of it, as some do. If the evidence points to the most probable interpretation of the text being that he is the rock, then that must be our conclusion as well. Does that mean that Jesus taught a papal succession which would not begin for some centuries? Not at all. What Jesus said was relevant to those of the evangelist’s day, or else the evangelist would not have recorded it. When coupled with the book of Acts, Peter’s “rock” status makes sense. God would use Peter, not to establish the *Roman Catholic* church, but *His* church.

As with any biblical discussion, there is much more that could be said. However, this discussion leaves a good reminder: when dealing with any biblical passage, the goal must be to understand the text itself, not how it can be used to defend (or attack) beliefs one presupposes are wrong. The reader must let the text guide him or her and not the other way around. Everyone who seeks the truth must be willing to accept the text's most probable interpretation, or else what one may be truly seeking is not the truth, but rather, self-justification.